

FLASHBACK

Interrupting the story to show the past



1 What is it?

Flashback

A flashback interrupts the main timeline to show an event from **earlier in time** — giving the reader context, backstory, or a reason behind a character's behaviour.

present moment → jump to the past → return

2 See it in action

Triggered memory

A smell or sound suddenly pulls a character back to a childhood memory.

Explaining fear

A flashback reveals why a character is afraid of water — a near-drowning years earlier.

In film

A sudden cut to black-and-white footage signals a jump into the past.

Dialogue-triggered

"Just like the day your father left," she said, and the room dissolved into memory.



You got this!

Look for a clear **trigger** — a smell, a sound, an object — that pulls the character (and reader) back into the past. That trigger is often worth analysing too.

FUN FACT

Flashbacks are sometimes called "analepsis" in formal literary terminology — the opposite technique, jumping FORWARD in time, is called "prolepsis" (a form of foreshadowing).

3 Why writers use it

Flashback helps writers: reveal a character's motivation or trauma, build suspense by withholding information until the right moment, and add emotional depth without needing a narrator to explain everything directly.

A flashback lets a writer control exactly WHEN the reader learns something — delaying key information for maximum emotional impact.

4 Where you'll spot it

War & trauma fiction

A sudden, intrusive flashback can mimic how memory actually works for someone processing trauma.

Detective stories

Flashbacks reveal clues the reader needs, exactly when the writer wants them revealed.



Watch out!

Don't confuse a flashback with simple backstory told in normal narration — a flashback specifically **INTERRUPTS** the present-moment story to dramatise a past event as if it's happening again.



Good spot!

Ask **why the writer chose THIS moment** to interrupt the story with a flashback — what does the reader need to understand right now that the past explains?

5 Quick recap

Interrupts the story to
show the past

Reveals context or
motivation

Returns to the present
after



Keep going!

Try writing a short scene where an ordinary object (a photo, a song) triggers a two-sentence flashback — notice how quickly it can shift the mood.